the Indus Valley but in the Indo-Iranian borderlands, en route to the Indus Valley'. Nor does the description of the Saraswati River in the Rig Veda fit the Ghaggar-Hakra River that dried up c. 2000 BCE, and instead maps on to the river called 'Haraxvaiti (in Avestan) or Harahuvati (in Old Persian)', which is very likely the Arghandab River, or less likely the Helmand River, both in modern Afghanistan.[42]

After the arrival of the Aryans to the Indus Valley, the locals (rural descendants of the Harappans) probably saw them as an aggressive bunch and their encounters were likely not all peaceful. One indicator of this is the very skewed genetic footprint of the Aryan male in later populations, despite the fact that, like all migrating groups, they had come with entire families. According to a scientific study in 2017, 'Genetic influx from Central Asia in the Bronze Age was strongly male-driven, consistent with the patriarchal, patrilocal and patrilineal social structure attributed to the inferred pastoralist early Indo-European society.'[43] Further, while archaeologists haven't found any telltale signs of war or invasion, it's reasonable to expect that the locals would have initially resisted the imposition of the Aryan language, religion and culture, since that's how such encounters usually play out.

The Aryans also brought with them a form of social hierarchy with priests at the top—a proto-varna system without endogamy (i.e., marrying only within a specific social group). They had no linguistic script and the need for it was reduced due to the lack of an urban civilization. The priests may also have impeded the rise of a script that might have democratized their oral chants and deflated their esoteric powers. Notably, such instincts seem alien to the Harappan ethos, given the ubiquity of the artefacts with their script on them. For instance, their script often appears as graffiti-like scribbles on stone blocks in non-elite parts of Dholavira, and as messages stamped on pottery items used by ordinary people (possibly brand or ownership details?).

After a millennium of mixing and migration in the subcontinent, numerous sites arose in the Gangetic Plain, whose settlers had learnt 'to fire a more durable and sophisticated series of ceramics known as painted gray ware (PGW)', writes historian Sudipta Sen.[44] They evolved social formations 'in which clans, lineages, and tribes began to yield to new ruling